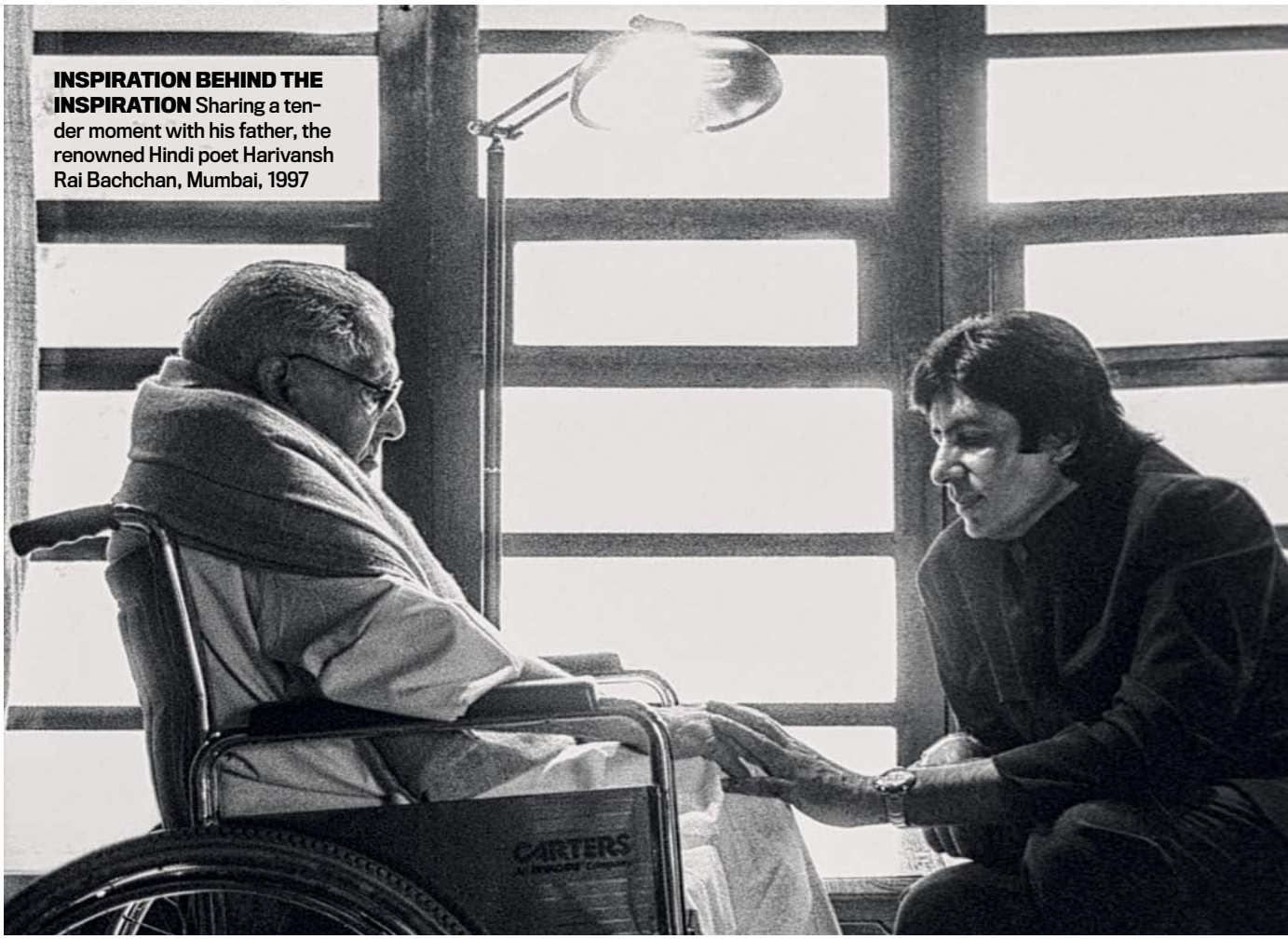


INSPIRATION BEHIND THE INSPIRATION Sharing a tender moment with his father, the renowned Hindi poet Harivansh Rai Bachchan, Mumbai, 1997

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

THE FIRST WAVE

Aysha Iqbal Viswamohan, professor, film studies, IIT Madras, is one of the many cinephiles who observed the Bachchan 'first wave' up close. That decade-long golden streak beginning with *Zanjeer* that would lead his contemporary Jeetendra to remark that he was Hindi cinema's "No. 1 to 10 star". Viswamohan attributes the actor's mass appeal to his ability to "lend a touch of authenticity" to the innumerable working-class heroes he played. Throughout, Bachchan was changing the definition of what constituted a mainstream Hindi film hero. Says Viswamohan: "He was a perfect antidote to the heightened romanticism of Rajesh Khanna. His unique embodiment of hegemonic masculinity fitted Salim-Javed's conception of a lone-ranger, urban cowboy, vigilante hero as popularised by Hollywood stars like Clint Eastwood and Steve McQueen. To this, he added a style of brooding intensity that harked back to Dilip Kumar. The result of this concoction was a new kind of morally ambiguous hero that suited the temper of the changing times."

But like in his new phase, Bachchan was bold with his choices at his peak, not allowing himself to be boxed in. The angry young man also dabbled memorably with romance (*Kabhi Kabhie*, *Silsila*), comedy (*Chupke Chupke*, *Amar Akbar Anthony*, *Mr Natwarlal*, *Namak Halal*), and served up a more sensitive side in films like *Alaap* (1977) and *Manzil* (1979), even if they weren't received as well as his action-heavy dramas. It's this variegated filmography that led to diehard fans like S.M.M. Ausaja, author, film historian and archivist, who started collecting Bachchan memorabilia in 1981 when still in school. Ausaja will admit that his star wasn't infallible. "It's frivolous to say he hasn't done bad films or there was no fall. But even in those, there are moments where he stood out," says Ausaja. Today, Ausaja sits on 5,000 items—posters, film stills, lobby cards, magazines, slides, transparencies, books, postcards. The labour of his love will make its way into *The Bachchans*, a four-kg, 600-page coffeetabler chronicling three generations of the family, beginning with Bachchan's grandfather, Pratap Narain Srivastava in Pratapgarh, and ending with his daughter-in-law Aishwarya Rai Bachchan. With Bachchan having